



A.S.I.A.

Addressing Structural Inequalities in Amsterdam

I often seek stories beyond my usual surroundings. But even in the Netherlands, including Amsterdam—our sometimes less-than-liberated capital—there are issues that deserve more attention. One such issue is the growing problem of racism against people of Asian descent. A recent report from UvA* reveals that half of individuals with Asian backgrounds experience racism. The pandemic worsened this problem, adding to a cultural backdrop where stereotypes and generalizations about Asians are deeply rooted in Dutch society.

This zine shines a light on seven eccentric and vibrant individuals with Asian heritage, capturing their energy and boldness. These individuals unapologetically embrace their uniqueness, using self-expression to (both directly and indirectly) challenge stereotypes and confront the discrimination they face.

*<https://www.uva.nl/shared-content/uva/en/news/press-releases/2024/03/half-of-dutch-people-of-chinese-background-experience-discrimination.html>

MY NAME IS SANDER DEKKER / ZINE 9

Photographs by Sander Dekker

A limited edition of forty copies with original photo.

This zine is copy number

BRANDON

As someone who has never not struggled with self-expression, I created an image for people to either love or hate—wearing my heart on my sleeve with an unhappy resting face that is perceived as either handsome or, as I imagine, provoking reactions like, “My fist wishes to parlay with thine face,” yelled from across the street. Of course, it’s likely something far less poetic and much more crass than that. Wearing headphones has become my makeshift armour: blinders for the ears to avoid unnecessary confrontation or acknowledgment of the world’s sharp edges.

Hurt people hurt people, as I’ve been told. This is partly the reason why I have such a guard up when it comes to letting people get close to me. As someone actively navigating recovery from alcohol and substance abuse—a journey fuelled by the complexities of post-traumatic stress disorder—I’ve long wrestled with feelings of inadequacy, negativity, and a fractured self-image. These struggles have been my constant companions, ever-present and deeply rooted.

Growing up gay in a small, conservative town in the southern Netherlands added another layer to my identity struggles, especially as someone of Asian descent. In a place where traditional values were deeply rooted and diversity often barely acknowledged, I constantly felt like an outsider, navigating a world that left little room for differences. The intersection of my sexuality and cultural heritage amplified feelings of isolation, as there were few, if any, role models or communities that reflected my experiences. Every interaction seemed to carry the weight of judgment or misunderstanding, forcing me to suppress parts of myself to fit in or avoid conflict. It was a challenging environment that shaped my sense of identity in profound, and often painful, ways.







My family's wide-ranging cultural heritage brought richness and diversity, but it also came with the weight of transgenerational trauma. Mental, physical, and sexual abuse overshadowed any chance for self-exploration or a healthy sense of self-worth. My parents—who met at the tender age of 14—were bound together by a codependency that was as inescapable as it was destructive. Their union, though well-intentioned, was forged in the fires of their own traumatic upbringings, where neglect and unresolved pain were ever-present. A concept that is difficult to grasp in the Netherlands, where the experiences of the Asian community are frequently overlooked and misunderstood.

Despite their best efforts, much of the actual parenting fell to my mother. She, without a doubt, is the strongest person I've ever known. She bore the weight of her struggles silently, shielding me as best she could from the mental and physical toll she endured. I vividly remember the calendula ointment that was a staple in our bathroom—used frequently by my mother to treat her bruises. When others asked about their own bruises, I'd recommend the same ointment, oblivious to the deeper implications of its ubiquitous presence in my childhood.

My mother's empathy and sensitivity, forged in the crucible of her own pain, stood in stark contrast to my father's hardened demeanour. Together, that created me—a perfect amalgamation of both their strengths and vulnerabilities. From my mother, I inherited a deep well of empathy and a heightened sensitivity to the world. From my father, I absorbed resilience and a guarded nature. These traits, while valuable, also became the source of my internal struggles—a constant push-and-pull between wanting to connect and fearing the consequences of doing so.

I've always wanted to be heard—to have my pain acknowledged and validated—but I've never found the right outlet. Expression has always felt like a double-edged sword, offering both release and exposure. For most of my life, I believed it was best to avoid oversharing or showing signs of weakness, fearing they would be dissected or used against me. But now, I'm starting to see the value in opening up—on my own terms.







– “I’ve come to understand that my family’s history in the Netherlands is deeply intertwined with the country’s colonial past.”

When I was invited to be part of this project, I didn’t hesitate. For the first time, I had recently undertaken a deep dive into my heritage as part Indonesian. The concept of transgenerational trauma became startlingly real to me. My grandparents—survivors of Japanese labour camps—were brought to the Netherlands, where they raised my mother, who in turn raised me. This legacy of pain and resilience was both literal and figurative—a foreign concept that shaped me without fully realizing it.

I’ve come to understand that my family’s history in the Netherlands is deeply intertwined with the country’s colonial past. My grandparents were forcibly displaced and brought to the Netherlands after Indonesia’s independence. Stripped of their homeland and culture, they faced the daunting challenge of rebuilding their lives in a foreign land that often treated them as outsiders. Despite their resilience, they carried the scars of war, displacement, and systemic racism, which became an unspoken but ever-present thread in our family’s story.

In the Netherlands, they were expected to assimilate into a society that neither fully acknowledged their trauma nor celebrated their heritage. This duality shaped their lives and the lives of their children, including my mother, who inherited both their strength and their struggles. Growing up under their care, my mother navigated a world of cultural dissonance, attempting to find a balance between preserving her roots and adapting to a society that often dismissed the complexities of post-colonial identity. In turn, she raised me with the same resilience, though I, too, inherited the weight of a history defined by survival, sacrifice, and the quiet endurance of a family seeking to belong in a land that wasn’t truly theirs.

Those family members, being performers, artists, and creatives like my grandparents, shaped my perspective. My grandmother, a vocalist, sang in her brother’s Indo-rock band. ▼



– “My grandparents quickly became the ones I looked up to the most, their lives serving as a constant reminder that creativity, passion, drive, and resilience are beautiful traits to celebrate.”

Growing up, their stories and adventures filled me with awe. As I spent more time with them, my admiration for their stories deepened, and I began to see them not just as family, but as role models. My grandparents quickly became the ones I looked up to the most, their lives serving as a constant reminder that creativity, passion, drive, and resilience are beautiful traits to celebrate.

Both of my parents come from deeply fractured backgrounds. My father’s side was shaped by stoicism and a certain emotional distance, while my mother’s side carried the scars of overt trauma but also an undeniable strength. These opposing dynamics played out within me, creating a constant internal battle to reconcile the two. It has taken years to even begin to unpack these layers, and I am still very much in the process of understanding how they have shaped my identity and my struggles.

I have one request you apply daily: don’t message me with concerns or compassion about how you had no idea I’ve been struggling. This was intentional, as I’ve carefully chosen to share my struggles on my own terms, creating space for reflection and understanding without the need for unsolicited sympathy or intervention. Instead, be kind to strangers moving forward. We tend to shy away from the common sense that everyone carries a cross to bear. Life comes with problems for all of us—some more than others, but struggles are universal. Everyone is carrying something. Be kind. It costs nothing but can mean everything.



– “Being both queer and Asian can be tricky. Sometimes it’s not safe to be queer in Asian spaces, and sometimes it’s not safe to be Asian in queer spaces. That’s the reality. But finding people who let you be completely yourself is life-changing.”

ANDRE

I’m Indonesian, born in Bandung, Java. I’m also half Chinese, though I didn’t grow up with that side of my heritage. Growing up in a very white town in the Netherlands, being the one Asian person, I often felt different. But back then, race wasn’t something people talked about. People weren’t aware of things like microaggressions or stereotypes.

As I got older, I realized I felt more at home with people who shared similar experiences. Joining the ballroom scene six years ago changed everything. I finally found queer people of color, including other queer Asians and Indonesians, who just got me. Being around them feels like I can simply be, with no explanations needed. It’s comforting in a way I didn’t know I needed.

Of course, my heritage has shaped me. At home, I grew up surrounded by Indonesian culture, but outside, I had to navigate a very white, Dutch environment. I spent so much time adapting, shapeshifting, and trying to fit in. Now, being older and surrounded by more queer Asians, I feel a stronger connection to my culture, though I’m still figuring it out.

Racism has been part of my life for as long as I can remember. I still get yelled at on the street by teenage boys mocking me with “ni hao.” It’s exhausting, and honestly, I don’t see it stopping as long as I live in Europe. There are countless stereotypes and biases, especially in the media or even the queer dating scene. I’ve just learned to focus on spaces where I feel safe, like ballroom.









Ballroom was a revelation. It's a space where queer and trans people of color are celebrated, where I don't have to explain myself. Seeing people walk the runway, stepping into their power, inspired me to embrace my own confidence. It's more than just a scene—it's my family, my community, my creative outlet. It's where I've discovered so much about myself, like my gender fluidity. Ballroom lets me play with my gender expression, whether I feel more masculine or feminine. It's all celebrated, and it's all me.

Do we challenge stereotypes? Probably, but I don't think about it like that. We're just being ourselves: unapologetically queer, joyful, and bold. Expectations from others don't matter to me anymore. What's important is staying true to who I am at my core, even as I continue to evolve. Authenticity isn't some final destination; it's a process.

Being both queer and Asian can be tricky. Sometimes it's not safe to be queer in Asian spaces, and sometimes it's not safe to be Asian in queer spaces. That's the reality. But finding people who let you be completely yourself is life-changing. That's where healing happens, in community.

I want the ballroom scene in the Netherlands to stay true to itself, even as it becomes more visible. We have to honor the culture and the pioneers who built it, while continuing to make it a place where queer and trans people of color can thrive. Beyond the balls, I want more programs that empower us and take care of our community.

I don't spend much energy hoping society will change. The world feels more divided than ever, and the hate—racism, homophobia, transphobia—is all so loud. Instead, I focus on building safer spaces where we can heal and recharge. That's where I can make a difference.

For the past four years, I've been building the Utrecht Ballroom Scene. Seeing people transform, watching them take their first steps into this world, finding themselves and their community - it's beautiful. That's the legacy I want to leave behind: a space where people can grow, connect, and feel like they belong.



ETHAN

At the start of 2022, I had no idea what to do for work. I became an actor by accident, as if the universe was telling me it was time for me to shine. My whole life, I've put others in the spotlight, never realizing I needed to stand in it myself. Now I'm able to address something very personal: the lack of people who look like me on screen.

Whenever I book an important TV or commercial job, I feel twice as proud. Not only did I nail the role, but I was hired for my queerness and my Vietnamese/Chinese look. It feels like progress—like I'm finally in a place where my identity and talent are valued. This is a huge contrast to my previous 9-to-5 office jobs, where I was often excluded, ridiculed, and discriminated against by managers who felt threatened by me. Still, without formal acting training, I have to work twice as hard to get noticed. It doesn't feel like work, though, and I don't mind. But I know I won't land a lead role in a Dutch production anytime soon. When was the last time

you saw an Asian lead here? Ever? The problem isn't a lack of Asian talent—we're here. We exist. The issue is that we don't get the same opportunities as our white colleagues. It's just the ugly reality.

My family has been incredible in supporting me as a trans person. Naturally, they have to get used to calling me Ethan, but I know they're working hard on getting it into their system... though my pronouns are still a bit of a foreign concept for most of them. My mom has her own way of adopting my name and pronouns; she calls me by my old and new name and calls me her "daughter/son", which I think is adorable. She's really trying to understand the concept of being nonbinary and trans. They're learning, and I know how lucky I am to have such an accepting Dutch-Vietnamese family. Even my relatives in Vietnam love me fully for who I am.







– “The problem isn’t a lack of Asian talent—we’re here. We exist. The issue is that we don’t get the same opportunities as our white colleagues. It’s just the ugly reality.”

I’ve been on T [testosterone] for almost six months now, and it’s been both incredible and an emotional whirlwind, to say the least. These past months I have felt more sensitive and vulnerable, and I have to catch myself and take a breath whenever I feel these intense feelings. But I do feel more and more aligned with myself every day. Going through this “second puberty” has its challenges—I get irritated and aggressive more easily—but I’ve found an outlet in my workouts. I’ve been working hard to build a more masculine, muscular frame, something I’ve craved my entire adult life. Seeing my muscles grow faster on T has been unbelievably satisfying.

I identify as trans masculine, a trans man, and nonbinary, and I use he/they pronouns. Since I was a kid, I’ve wanted to be a boy. People often confuse “nonbinary” with sexual orientation and ask if I’m bi. If I had to define my attraction, I’d call myself a straight man—though I don’t love comparing myself to some straight men.

Ignorance about queerness and trans identities is common, both among Dutch people and within Asian and Vietnamese communities. Many aren’t willing to educate themselves; these ideas often feel too foreign. On top of that, I’ve faced racism throughout my life—slurs shouted by adults and kids alike in Amsterdam and even in my hometown Rotterdam. It looks like youth are super bored these days, so they behave like trash. I used to feel safer on my bike, passing by unnoticed, but now even that’s changed. Kids in Amsterdam and Rotterdam have started yelling racial slurs as I ride past. It feels like they’ve completely lost control. Recently, I had an incident at Albert Heijn in Rotterdam with two POC youths who tried to intimidate me and I called the manager. He just looked at the boys and said, “can you go away?” When one of the boys called me “miss” I corrected him, saying I am a “sir,” and he laughed at me. The manager didn’t even react to that. I told him these boys were intimidating me and asked him why he didn’t do anything, and he said: “I didn’t see it happen.” FYI, he was white. Ignorance is so bliss... ▼

One of my greatest accomplishments is overcoming depression. It was the hardest shit I've ever had to deal with—living without hope, convinced life wouldn't get better. My spiral began after being dropped from a major project (which had nothing to do with acting, by the way) by a cold, one-line email. My trust was shattered, and I felt cheated. While still in university, I thought that project would mean I didn't have to graduate. Instead, it was the universe telling me it was finally time for me to face my biggest fears. For the next year and a half, I lived in a terrifying, dark, and lonely place.

Months later, still depressed but determined, I graduated and made a choice: a job or do what I truly wanted. I chose the latter and went on a five-week solo trip to New York. Crashing New York Fashion Week as a photographer and telling a family member I loved them—something I'd never said before—was transformative. When I returned to Amsterdam, I realized my depression was gone. By stepping outside my comfort zone and staying true to myself, I'd healed. Since then, I've made it a priority to keep growing, never slipping back into that hell.

My mom is my biggest supporter. She's always encouraged me to pursue my talents. During my depression, when I didn't want to graduate, her constant reminders—"You're almost there, don't quit halfway"—kept me going. She cared for me when I couldn't eat, trying to understand a word like "depression," which doesn't even exist in Vietnamese. Though we clash at times, and she's extra hard on me because she believes in me, I know she'll always have my back.

In The Netherlands, Southeast Asians are raising their voices and speaking up more, which is progress. But I would like to see more vulnerability. Sharing your feelings, especially deep feelings, is cathartic and a bonding experience. I wish I could experience more of this within my community. It seems like the ones I truly connect to are spiritual, like myself.

Amidst all the craziness and chaos in the world, I'm so grateful that I get to live this crazy life and I'd never trade it for someone or anything else.



MAUREEN

When people ask where I'm from, I'm often unsure what to share. I was born on Sumatra, moved to the Netherlands at two and a half years old, and grew up in Almere and Amsterdam. My father is Dutch, my mother is Moluccan-Indonesian. I hold Dutch citizenship but am clearly mixed-race. Instead of explaining the whole story, I sometimes ask what they mean: 'Do you mean where I grew up, where my parents are from? Or where I was born?' Most of the time, they don't even know themselves. They hesitate, then say, 'Oh, yeah—where your parents are from,' and quickly add 'or something.' As if that would make it less awkward. The question often feels strange and unnecessary, diving straight into someone's identity without considering the complexities behind it.

Two years ago a teacher said, "Wait, you weren't born in the Netherlands? Well, your Dutch is so good!" Or I'll generally hear, "Ha, but I find you so Dutch." As if that's supposed to be a compliment. It's hard to explain how comments like these—though some of them well-intended—aren't flattering.

When my parents divorced at age seven, my upbringing split into two distinct worlds. During the week I was with my mother, who is Protestant and raised with strict traditions: no elbows on the table, always accept things with your right hand, pray before every meal, sit with your legs crossed, never talk back to your mother... And liking boys? Forget it. I naturally resisted all of it. I didn't understand why these rules existed, especially when I saw my school friends living much more freely. Even teachers told me I didn't need to pray before lunch.









– ‘I’ve realized that society’s obsession with categorizing people limits our ability to truly see each other. It perpetuates stereotypes, creates exclusion, and erases the richness of duality.

At the time I felt much more at home in the Dutch side of my upbringing, with my father, where I experienced a sense of freedom. For years, I rejected my mother’s culture and refused to learn Indonesian, wanting to be more like my Dutch father and friends. Back then, I felt pride when people said I was “verkaast” [literally “cheese’d,” assimilated into Dutch culture]. But deep down, I was denying a part of myself. I began to hate the things about me that didn’t fit into the Dutch mold—especially my appearance.

In school, I was constantly reminded of my “otherness.” One day a teacher called my father, worried about my weight. My father laughed and replied that she’d be shocked by how much I eat in a day. My body shape has always been slim, but I did compare myself to classmates—none of whom were Asian—and felt like I wasn’t enough. I didn’t have an eating disorder; I just had a fast metabolism and a deep love for food! Nonetheless, the teacher’s comment, together with

some other ones, stuck with me. It made me feel small, like I was being watched. The truth is, half of the Asian population has a similar body type. It took years to reframe how I saw myself and accept my body as it is. A single comment about someone’s body—no matter how casual—can shape how they feel about themselves for a long time.

Now, I belong to a community that celebrates diversity. I’m a theater actress and a performer at festivals and events, surrounded by people who embrace their uniqueness and uplift each other. Ironically, I get more comments about my body, my features, and my quirks now than ever. I sometimes have to remind myself that they are a strength—what sets me apart and gets the job done. Working in this field has taught me to accept myself and how others see me.







I've always felt at home in Dutch society. But as I've grown older, I've realized there's a part of me that doesn't quite fit. A part that connects with my mother and her traditions, even though I spent so many years pushing them away. There are also parts of Dutch culture where I feel I'll never fully belong, even though I was raised in it. This duality used to make me uncomfortable, but now it helps me form my own opinions and follow my intuition. I've started asking my mother more questions about our family history and about the language I once refused to learn. I started thinking about those first two and a half years of my life on the other side of the world, a time I don't consciously remember but that shaped me nonetheless.

In 2020, just before the pandemic hit, I felt a sudden and overwhelming urge to visit Indonesia. It was the strangest feeling, and I remember that night like it was yesterday. It felt like something was calling me and completely took over. Without any hesitation, I booked a two-week ticket to Bali. I didn't think about bringing anyone with me or asking for time off work. I only felt a slight guilt for not inviting my mother, who had only been to Indonesia once since moving to the Netherlands. But I needed to do this alone, as this was my first time going there since birth.

My trip to Bali was a sensory overload. It felt like every part of me—my skin, my senses, my soul—was completely open and alive. My heart was skipping with joy. I couldn't quite explain what was happening in my body—was this what “home” felt like? I chose Bali over Sumatra because I wanted to experience the “tourist” side of Indonesia first and not feel completely isolated, especially since I didn't speak the language. But I looked “too Indonesian” to be seen as a tourist by the locals, who spoke to me in the native language. Or they gave me strange looks because they couldn't place my behaviour or my appearance.

The most profound moment came during a jungle trek. Within five minutes, I broke down and was sobbing uncontrollably—ugly crying, even. I felt like I was returning to Mother Earth, surrendering myself to something far greater than me. I had never experienced such an intense feeling of gratitude as I did there.



– “My mixed cultural background, while sometimes a source of confusion, has ultimately become a source of strength. It allows me to broaden my perspectives on identity and form one that’s truly my own.”

On my second-to-last day, my uncle messaged me on Instagram: “You’re in Bali?! Why didn’t you say anything? Let’s meet up!” My mother’s brother had a criminal past—that’s the only thing I knew about him. At first, I was hesitant. But I let myself be guided by... whatever it was. And there I was, standing by the side of the road, waiting for him. He drove by on a scooter, and I wasn’t sure it was him until he stopped, looked at me, and called my name. He gave me the warmest, longest hug I’ve ever received from a family member. I didn’t think it would affect me so much, given that I never met him. I thought the jungle was the highlight of my trip, but everything came together in my uncle’s arms. I could have collapsed from the love, the release, the incomprehension—but mostly the unconditional love.

That trip changed me. Since then, I’ve felt deeply that Indonesia is a part of me—the land, the trees, the traditions, my ancestors. Gradually, I’m giving it an even bigger place in my being and the arts.

My mixed cultural background, while sometimes a source of confusion, has ultimately become a source of strength. It allows me to broaden my perspectives on identity and form one that’s truly my own. I’ve realized that society’s obsession with categorizing people limits our ability to truly see each other. It perpetuates stereotypes, creates exclusion, and erases the richness of duality. I hope we can all stay open to looking at people with more curiosity and less judgment.



– “Growing up as someone with Chinese-Indonesian heritage in the Netherlands, I’ve always navigated a complex intersection of identities. There were moments when I felt like I didn’t fully belong, caught between the expectations of cultural traditions, the pressures of Western society, and my own struggles with being gay.”

KENNETH

Growing up as someone with Chinese-Indonesian heritage in the Netherlands, I’ve always navigated a complex intersection of identities. There were moments when I felt like I didn’t fully belong, caught between the expectations of cultural traditions, the pressures of Western society, and my own struggles with being gay. Reconciling these parts of myself was not an easy journey. For years, I wrestled with feelings of shame and fear, trying to find a way to embrace who I truly am.

A turning point for me was discovering the work of Pete Wu and Sioe Jeng Tsao.

Pete Wu’s bold exploration of what it means to be queer and Asian in his book *De Bananengeneratie* resonated deeply with me. His words made me feel seen in a way I hadn’t before, showing me that I wasn’t alone in my experiences. Similarly, Sioe Jeng Tsao’s activism and unapologetic presence taught me the value of owning my story, not just for myself but for others who might still feel invisible. Their courage and advocacy made me realize that representation isn’t just important, it’s vital. ▼





***– “In the face of adversity, there is resilience.
And in representation, there is power.”***

Inspired by them, I strive to carry that sense of purpose into my work as a medical doctor in sexual healthcare and as a sexologist. In my role, I champion diversity and inclusion, particularly for people whose voices are often silenced, whether due to their ethnicity, gender identity, or sexual orientation. My work focuses on providing accessible and equal sexual healthcare to groups in vulnerable positions, including LGBTQIA+ individuals, newcomers, and, in particular, transgender and gender-diverse persons with a refugee background who navigate intersections of race, class, and identity.

I believe that representation matters in every space, in literature, in healthcare, and the broader cultural dialogue. By stepping into these spaces and showing up as my authentic self, I hope to

contribute to a world where others feel empowered to do the same. My heritage, once a source of inner conflict, is now my strength. It drives me to build bridges, challenge stereotypes, and create inclusive environments where everyone can thrive.

In the face of adversity, there is resilience. And in representation, there is power. For me, embracing my identity, both as someone with Chinese-Indonesian roots and as a gay man, has been a journey toward self-acceptance and a commitment to making space for others to do the same and live their lives proud, unapologetically and with their head held high.





–“For me, storytelling is about universal human experiences rather than race. I believe that stories people can relate to on an emotional level helps normalize diversity in all its forms.”

SHARON

I was born in the United States and raised in Hong Kong from the age of five, growing up with a blend of cultures. My mother is Chinese, while my father’s heritage is European—half Romanian, half Polish. I grew up in a rocky household. My family dynamic ultimately shifted when my parents separated when I was twelve, but before that, I spent my formative years in a mix of environments, mainly in Hong Kong and China, where I attended international schools. Although those schools were westernized, Chinese culture was always central to my upbringing. Yet, I never felt out of place, even though I wasn’t fully immersed in the local culture; my mother kept me immersed in Chinese traditions.

Interestingly, my early education also had a religious dimension—my father is Jewish, and my mom converted me when I was a baby, so I grew up in a Jewish household. I attended a Jewish school up until middle school, where I was one of the few non-white students. This made me aware of my race from a young age, and how, in this community, my mother was the minority as well. I remember being taught the Torah not as religion, but as fact. It wasn’t until I grew older that I started to differentiate religion from science—learning about evolution while also being taught the creation story of Adam and Eve, which was a confusing contrast.

At the age of 18, cut off from my family, I embraced my newfound emancipation and left home, moving to London to pursue modeling and study. After a brief try in New York. My parents carry a lot of generational trauma, as Jews on my father’s side and Chinese farmers on my mother’s side. My home life was always ▼





unstable, growing up surrounded by anger, strife, and drug addiction, and my father's narcissism leaving him unable to provide much support. International schooling in Hong Kong led me to romanticize the West. Moving to Europe seemed like a fresh start, a safe haven in a world I idealized from a distance. However, London and New York didn't provide the escape I had imagined. They were pauses, temporary escapes from a toxic home life, but they didn't lead to the personal or career growth I hoped for. I returned to Hong Kong to live with friends and save money, eventually making my way to Amsterdam.

I had initially tried to break into modeling but was repeatedly rejected due to my size. I had some hope when I settled in Amsterdam, but found the environment here to be even less accepting of my figure. My journey as a model, it seemed, was not meant to be.

I've always found solace in the creative. I've always loved the arts. Storytelling is a really big passion of mine. There are just so many different ways to tell a story, and for me—because I come from a financially unstable background—finding a career was really important. I was a bit nervous going into a fine arts degree because I felt jobs and a steady income in that area to be unstable. So I pursued fashion branding. During my

studies, I also discovered a passion for other creative outlets like photography and videography. These pursuits gave me more tools to tell stories, and I embraced them fully. Where I once chased to be in front of the camera, I now am finding inspiration behind the camera.

As a half-Asian person in Europe, I've had an interesting experience. Growing up in Hong Kong, I was mostly seen as White—idealized for my fluency in English, Eurocentric features, and height. Being mixed didn't make me stand out as “Asian” in a way that might have been expected elsewhere. But when I moved to Europe, especially in places like London or Amsterdam, I was suddenly the “Asian” person, often subject to ignorant comments. In England, some man asked me, “Where are you from?” and he replied, “Oh, the chinks. Love their take-out food.” It genuinely wasn't malicious, I didn't feel attacked. It was just pure ignorance. The same thing happened in the Netherlands when I first moved here. A group of little Dutch kids walked by me and probably chant ‘ching chong’ and ‘Poepchinees.’ I was confused. When I was working at a retail store, someone asked me where I was from. He said, “Oh, Hong Kong, hakuna matata.” So ridiculous, it doesn't even refer to the right continent! [Laughs]







– When I was working at a retail store, someone asked me where I was from. He said, “Oh, Hong Kong, hakuna matata.”

These moments, though uncomfortable, felt almost validating in a way. Growing up, I was often told I wasn’t “Chinese enough,” as if my white side overshadowed my Chinese heritage. Now, in Europe, my Asian identity is undeniable, even if it’s sometimes acknowledged with ignorance.

The discrimination against Asians amplified during the pandemic. Discrimination against South-East Asians in particular, led to this alien feeling. Where, for the first time, I became viscerally aware of the societal prejudice against my race, my appearance - my identity. But even with this, I recognize a certain privilege I have with my mixed heritage. My white side shields me in some ways from the harshest of racism, and I’m very aware of that dynamic.

Though I haven’t yet created work directly related to my Asian heritage, I am very aware that my heritage and upbringing inevitably influence my perspective and the work I make. I’ve always wanted to share my mother’s incredible life story. She grew up in a farming family in rural China; where

traditional Chinese values were very prominent. She was traded at birth, with already six daughters - she was the seventh. Her parents wanted to have a son, because in China traditionally the son carries the family name and wealth. So she was traded as a baby for a son with another family. But then her mother got so sick from her maternal instincts that she couldn’t live without her real baby and traded her back. It’s a tale of resilience and hardship.

But I worry, because Chinese culture in the West often carries so many negative connotations. Still, I feel compelled to tell that story—someday. For me, storytelling is about universal human experiences rather than race. I believe that stories people can relate to on an emotional level helps normalize diversity in all its forms. Through my work, I hope to break down the barriers of ignorance, allowing people to see beyond stereotypes and appreciate the richness of human experience. And this, I believe, is the core of the project—telling stories that connect us as humans, rather than as races or nationalities.



– “When I’m moving, I love to tangle myself, and feel the sensations when my body parts are touching, stretching, and squeezing each other.”

QIYUN

My performance/research, A Knot Manifesto, was set out from my movement practice. When I’m moving, I love to tangle myself, and feel the sensations when my body parts are touching, stretching, and squeezing each other. The shapes of literal human knots are the exact reflection of my reality: how I, as a queer Asian living in Europe, carry so many social knots, constantly navigating different identities and communities, while never feeling completely fitting in any of them. The knots aren’t things to be undone. Knots are who I am.

The perfect example is my name. I always think of how the 23 strokes of three square Chinese characters dissolved, transformed, and contorted into 10 English letters, with the family name and given name switched in positions.

Contortion, for a long time, has been fetishized and exoticized into a “flexible Asian female body.” Because of my East-Asian appearance and ways of moving, I always got categorized as being a Contortion artist, even though I had never trained in Contortion, but just naturally moved in a twisted way and enjoyed staying in knotted positions. To understand this stereotype and figure out how to subvert it, I started to train Contortion last year and learned the background knowledge of this long-existing art form through books and articles. I wanted to add my twist to this traditional art and trick the audience’s perception of Asian beauty and flexibility.











– “Instead of constantly trying to unknot the tensions, only when the East and West are woven even tighter together, can we understand each other better.”

For me, the body is always political. Mine was trained for years in a certain way—my Chinese Folk Dance training was all about discipline, reaching beyond the body limits with plastered smiles. But as I found myself doing New Way Voguing (a dance style created by Black and Latinx people around the 1980s in New York), I realized a knotted body can carry resistance and joy too. It almost symbolizes a survival strategy for queer people. First embody the boxes and controls the mainstream society expects, but we also know when to break free, mock the strictness, and throw the lines into a knot of joy. With the unreadable shapes, we challenge perceptions. The knots make people stop, marvel, and love us for who we truly are.

I have a bachelor's degree in Chinese-English Translation, and have since positioned myself as a cultural agent. It seems an easier task to reimagine making performances through translation—reinterpreting narratives

and reshaping presentations of certain bodies. But the harder task is perhaps, to understand that instead of constantly trying to unknot the tensions, only when the East and West are woven even tighter together, can we understand each other better.

Therefore, the audience of my performances is so important in this. Their reactions aren't just passive—they're part of the performance too. How they respond and how they engage with what I'm doing, has the power to reinforce or challenge the message. I want to create a space where they're forced to reflect on their assumptions. Where they're invited to see my body in a new light—not as an object to be looked at, but as a real, full, complex being. A Knot Manifesto is my genuine offering. It's about acknowledging everything that's been twisted around and inside of me. Hopefully, this journey will help others do the same—find the freedom to exist as the knots they truly are.







Andre, Brandon, Ethan, Kenneth, Maureen, Qiyun,
and Sharon—thank you so much! Your openness and
individuality have made this zine not only meaningful but
also beautiful.

With lots of love, Sander

